



ARCHAEOLOGICAL SURVEY OF INDIA IN CUSTODY

At Rs 300 crore for 3,653 buildings, it works out to just Rs 8 lakh spent on preserving each monument of national importance, paying its 8,000 staff and 40 museums. It's a miracle that the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) is able to do its job. But in an age when heritage has become an implacable part of a nation's signature in the global marketplace, this public custodian needs to do more. Yes, the institution, established with Alexander Cunningham as its head, has kept to its original mandate of recording and excavating (take the Dholavira find, the only Harappan Civilisation site in India) but it's time for it to step into the future. It has weathered politicisation (anyone remember the artists' impression of the Ram temple at Ayodhya in 2003?) and politics (take its flip-flop on the Ram Setu's historic value) and now it needs to work with corporates and the public to market the nation's heritage. Sure it



makes Rs 63 crore a year from selling entry tickets to the 277 lakh visitors to its monuments, but in a nation which boasts of the Taj Mahal that is chicken feed. Of late the ASI has shown signs of life—the glass ceiling that technocrats feel they are up against seems like shattering with the hiring of an outside professional as director, conservation, and scientific collaborations, such as one on terrain mapping with IIT Kanpur, are now more common. But until the nation's heritage doesn't become the citizen's concern, its spirit of preservation will not be fulfilled. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

ARCHAEOLOGICAL pursuits in India started with the efforts of Sir William Jones, who put together a group of antiquarians to form the Asiatic Society in 1784.

RUINS OF TIME: A courtyard in Sindh (1924) during excavation



ASIATIC SOCIETY, KOLKATA ABODE OF LEARNING

For Sir William Jones, Asia was the "nurse of sciences" and the "inventress of delightful and useful arts". The Asiatic Society, despite its changing nomenclature, has been precisely that, with its collection of books, journals, paintings and sculptures outgrowing it and necessitating another museum, the Indian Museum. Sir William's idea also inspired Sir James Mackintosh two decades later to set up the Asiatic Society of Mumbai. "The Time magazine in its May issue this year named our library the best," says society's General Secretary Ramakanta Chakraborty. From an illuminated manuscript of the Quran to an autographed copy of *Shahjahan Padshahnama*, the library houses 1.49 lakh books and 80,000 journals, while the museum boasts of an Ashoka rock edict dating back to 250 B.C. The society funds several projects in nu-

SUBIR HAIDER



READER'S DELIGHT: The library of the society is open to the public

merous fields that are undertaken by eminent scholars. Over 40 research scholars are working with the society presently. If there is any one institution that can be called the cradle of modern learning, then it has to be this. **by Elora Sen**

THE FOUNTAINHEAD The Asiatic Society remained the chief advisory body to the government of India on scientific subjects. The initial activities of the society led to the formation of the Indian Meteorological Department in 1875, the Zoological Survey of India in 1911 and the Botanical Survey of India in 1912.